Drishadwati and Saraswati rivers: the Caggar [Ghaggar] and Sursuti [Sarsuti] of our barbarous maps.'[23]

The present-day Sarsuti River is little more than a stream that rises in the Siwalik foothills just east of Ambala in Haryana. As it flows south-west it is joined by another stream before merging with the Ghaggar River, which itself is a pretty insignificant river, except in the immediate aftermath of the monsoon. However, the former course of the Ghaggar survives in the form of an extensive dried-up river-bed. Modern satellite imagery confirms the existence of just such a palaeo-channel, in the form of a dried-up river course that extends westwards deep into the Rajasthan desert and continues all the way to the coast. So there was once a river here that ran all the way from the mountains to the sea. Yet all the scientific evidence shows that it ceased to flow to the sea several thousand years *before* the first of the Arya ever set foot in India. This was largely as a consequence of reduced monsoon rainfall combined with tectonic activity in the Himalayan foothills that redirected the Ghaggar's upper reaches into the Jumna River. Reduced seasonal rainfall and snow-melt continued to fill its upper channels but its lower course simply disappeared in the sand.

So how could this dried-up river-bed ever have been the site of the celebrated Saraswati of old?

The answer is that the Punjabi Sarsuti-Ghaggar was not the original Saraswati. That word derives from the Proto-Indo-Iranian word *saras-vat-i*, referring to pools, marshes or still water. It has the same linguistic derivation as the Avestan *Haraxvati* and the Old Persian *Harauvati*, these being the ancient names of a river today known as the Harut in south-western Afghanistan. The Harut has its source in three streams that rise in the mountains south-east of Herat. It then flows south for some 250 miles before ending in the salt-marshes of Hamun-i-Helmand, a shallow